

Braxton Bragg's incursion into Kentucky in the fall of 1862, Thomas was offered command of the army, but refused, and began a pattern of quiet loyalty and steady service. At Perryville in October 1862, he was Buell's titular second-in-command, but was unable to influence the course of the battle.

During the next two critical Western campaigns, Thomas served superbly as the Union army's second-in-command. At Stones River and Chickamauga, he held a reserve position, to which the rest of the army could rally, or withdraw. During the Tullahoma Campaign that preceded Chickamauga, it was Thomas who led the Union advance, and at Chattanooga in November 1863, it was the Army of the Cumberland, now under his direct command, that stormed the Rebel works on Missionary Ridge, winning the battle for Ulysses S. Grant.

Thomas's Army of the Cumberland was also central to General Sherman's Atlanta Campaign in 1864. The logistical, intelligence, and staff work of Thomas's command were integral to the advance against Joseph E. Johnston, and later it was Thomas who stopped the Confederates under John Bell Hood at Peachtree Creek on July 20, in their first attempt to end the siege of Atlanta.

When Hood moved north to sever Sherman's supply and communication lines in Tennessee, Thomas was sent to stop him. At Franklin on November 30, John M. Schofield, under Thomas's command, repulsed Hood's assaults and bought time for Thomas to concentrate all available forces at Nashville. Thomas waited almost too long to assemble his troops, so Grant became impatient and actually began the journey west to intervene personally. But Thomas had the situation under control, and as soon as the wet ground had dried sufficiently for a successful assault, he attacked Hood in a vicious two-day battle that all but destroyed the Confederate Army of Tennessee. For this victory Thomas now became known as "The Sledge of Nashville."